Yellow Leaves Diagnosis

Yellow leaves are a message. Let's translate it.

GETTING STARTED

Nothing panics a new plant parent like yellowing leaves, and the internet usually makes it worse — too many guesses, all stated with total confidence. This worksheet turns the panic into a calm process: describe what you actually see, test the soil, rule out the usual suspects one by one, and write down what you did so next time starts closer to the answer.

PRINT IT RIGHT

- US Letter paper, portrait, 100 % scale (“Actual size”, never “Fit to page”).
- Print a few and keep them with the plant profiles — one worksheet per mystery.
- If you can, snap a photo before you remove any leaves; patterns in the whole plant matter.

HOW TO WORK THE CASE

- Tick every pattern that matches — several can be true at once.
- Do the finger test on the soil *before* you water again; it is the single best clue.
- The worksheet walks you to a top suspect, an action, and a follow-up date.

> **Remember:** one yellow leaf now and then — even a cheerful curve at the bottom of an otherwise happy plant — is just a leaf retiring. Diagnose *patterns*, not individual leaves.

A free sheet from the Houseplant Helper Printables pack. Local PDF, no account needed. This sheet is gentle education for houseplants, not medical advice — for you or the plant.

Yellow Leaves — Diagnosis Worksheet

Case #: _____ Plant: _____ Date first noticed: _____

1 · WHAT THE YELLOWING LOOKS LIKE (TICK ALL THAT FIT)

- ☐ Oldest / lowest leaves only
- ☐ Newest growth paling instead
- ☐ Yellow all over, evenly
- ☐ Yellow between green veins
- ☐ Brown, crisp edges + yellowing
- ☐ Tips only, rest of leaf green
- ☐ Yellow, then soft or mushy
- ☐ Yellow with tiny webs or dots underneath

2 · GROUND FACTS (THE HONEST PART OF THE CASE)

Finger test, two knuckles deep — soil is: ○ bone dry ○ evenly damp ○ wet days after watering | Days since last watering: _____

Recent changes (tick all): ☐ moved location ☐ repotted ☐ just fertilized ☐ heater or AC turned on ☐ cold draft ☐ nothing at all

3 · THE SUSPECT LINE-UP

Bottom leaves one or two at a time, plant otherwise healthy	Natural aging — or a long dry spell. Verify with the soil test.
Soil constantly wet, drooping, stems going squishy	Overwatering — let it dry properly, check the drainage hole.
Crisp edges, dry soil, quicker leaf drop	Underwatering or very low humidity — water thoroughly on schedule.
Pale and washed-out all over, little new growth	Not enough light — move nearer a bright window.
Veins stay green, leaf yellows between them	Hungry — feed at half strength during the growing season.
Sudden mass yellowing or dots, webs, sticky spots	Shock, cold, or pests — inspect under the leaves with a light.

4 · MY VERDICT AND PLAN

Top suspect: _____ why: _____

What I will do this week:

_____

Follow-up check on: _____ Leaves still declining then? ○ yes ○ no Next suspect: _____

One change at a time is the rule of plant medicine: move it, feed it, or repot it — never all three on the same confused afternoon.